

Von der Leyen's economic blind spot

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-09-09 14:05

【メール原文】

Presented by Connect Europe By GERARDO FORTUNA with GREGORIO SORGI CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you, wishing a happy Draghiversary to all who

Presented by Connect Europe

By GERARDO FORTUNA

with GREGORIO SORGI

PRESENTED BY

Send tips here | Follow us @gerardofortuna @NicholasVinocur @GabrielGavin | Listen to Playbook and view in your browser

CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you, wishing a happy Draghiversary to all who celebrate. It's been two years since Mario Draghi dropped the big competitiveness report that now drives the EU's agenda (more on that below). It's also exactly a week until Ursula von der Leyen delivers her annual State of the Union. Seven days to kill — but don't worry, Playbook has plenty to keep you busy.

In today's Playbook:

- António Costa's budget tour reaches its main event as he meets Friedrich Merz in Berlin.
- Jordan Bardella goes to court over who gets to work for him — and who pays.
- Faces in the crowd: Rasmus Andresen, François Paradol, Piotr Serafin, Patricia Reilly, Donald Tusk, Robin Vink, Teresa Ribera, Gelu Calacean, Friedrich Merz, John Alistair Clarke, Iratxe García, Michele Piergiovanni, Jean-Claude Juncker, Radosław Sikorski, Thomas Lunau and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian put Draghi's grand plan for Europe through the Draghi-o-Meter — two years after his existential warning, what's actually been delivered?

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

****A message from Connect Europe:** The EU has proposed a new Cybersecurity Act. Achieving increased security in our tech is necessary, but a new independent study by Assembly Research raises serious doubts on how the Commission intends to achieve the objective. Read more here. ******

* Sponsor: Connect Europe

* The advertisement relates to EU technology and connectivity policy and promotes the FT-Connect Europe Forum, highlighting debates on the Digital Networks Act, market consolidation, investment and the balance between security and innovation in Europe's digital sector.

More information about political advertising here .

DRIVING THE DAY

BACK TO THE FUTURE: Ursula von der Leyen spent years building what she called a “geopolitical Commission” as the specter of war rose up the agenda. But what happens if the next crisis is more about bonds than bombs?

There are reasons for nervousness: German borrowing costs — a closely watched indicator of the state of the economy — reached a 15-year high last month, and France and Italy aren’t far behind. Investors are getting twitchier. Governments are paying more for debt, leading them to confront tough choices between raising taxes and lowering spending — both unpopular paths that risk inflaming the political climate. The far-right Alternative for Germany’s victory in Saxony-Anhalt on Sunday and the National Rally’s lead in French presidential polls aren’t happening in a vacuum.

We’re not back in 2012 just yet, but the economic headwinds raise a question: Has von der Leyen built the right team for the next big shock?

Some think not: Experienced EU people have told Playbook they worry her team isn’t built for a moment that demands more economic heft. And a senior EU official pointed Playbook to what they see as a revealing blind spot: Von der Leyen currently has no permanent senior economic adviser in her cabinet. Amid Brussels’ turf wars and power plays, that’s a stick her critics use to beat her.

Case in point: Michele Piergiovanni is acting senior economic adviser while simultaneously serving as digital adviser, with a portfolio ranging from competition to space and defense. Economic adviser Patricia Reilly, also in an acting capacity, handles financial services alongside agriculture and health. She’s a veterinarian by training. Gelu Calacean also supports Piergiovanni on the European Semester, though his main area is social affairs.

Defense is different: When defense adviser Thomas Lunau left the president’s cabinet, the vacancy was swiftly filled by Robin Vink.

Remember when economics was all Brussels could talk about? When the EU obsessed over deficits and bailouts, Jean-Claude Juncker became Commission president after running Luxembourg’s finances and chairing the group of eurozone finance ministers.

The Commission’s argument: “The president has dedicated economic expertise in the Cabinet, the Commission and externally,” Commission spokesperson Arianna Podestà told Playbook. In other words: the EU executive hardly lacks economists, and they’re attached to powerful departments and commissioners.

The question is what expertise sits closest to the president when she needs to make the big calls. Because ultimately geopolitics and the economy are the same thing. And wars have to be paid for.

Enter Europe’s bond salesman ... Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin is in Asia, arriving in Tokyo today with a simple mission: Convince some of the world’s biggest investors to buy EU debt.

The pitch: EU bonds offer Japanese and Korean investors diversification — and something close to German levels of safety at a cheaper price, according to a person familiar with preparations for the trip.

Brussels goes borrowing: The Commission increased its 2026 issuance target from €160 billion to €180 billion in May amid extra security financing needs, including Ukraine. SAFE defense loans are also part of

the borrowing program.

The bottom line: In a more unstable world, the EU's shift toward defense, security and protecting trade was roundly supported. But events move fast: Is the "geopolitical" Commission now looking like yesterday's solution?

BIG AND BREAKING

RIBERA'S WISHLIST: In a wide-ranging interview with POLITICO, the Commission's second-in-command, Teresa Ribera, takes aim at Big Tech and Big Oil, raises an eyebrow at Google's U.S. reprieve — and argues Europe should talk to China without going soft.

CAN THE CENTER HOLD? France's centrists are struggling to unite behind a presidential candidate as the far right and far left gain in the polls.

PROGRESS REPORT: Two years after Mario Draghi warned that Europe faced "existential" economic decline, national politics stands in the way of implementing many of his ideas. POLITICO rates how his competitiveness plan is faring across 13 key areas.

GARCÍA TO RUN AGAIN: The Socialists and Democrats' group Chair Iratxe García confirmed she'll seek a fourth two-and-a-half-year term in the internal leadership election slated for the second October plenary, saying the European Parliament's top jobs reshuffle will determine "whether the pro-European alliance will continue or not," Max Grier reports.

TECH SUPPORT: The EU is looking to Israel to support its new push for high-tech air defense and space capabilities, Gabriel Gavin scooped.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

* Sponsor: Connect Europe

* The advertisement relates to EU technology and connectivity policy and promotes the FT-Connect Europe Forum, highlighting debates on the Digital Networks Act, market consolidation, investment and the balance between security and innovation in Europe's digital sector.

More information about political advertising [here](#).

COSTA HEADS TO BERLIN

THE BIG ONE: António Costa arrives in Berlin today for a critical stop on his capitals tour. The European Council president will test whether there's room for compromise with one of the governments pushing hardest for cuts to the EU's long-term budget, Gregorio Sorigi reports.

Budget bogeyman: Costa's afternoon meeting with Friedrich Merz comes three days after the German chancellor's party suffered a bruising loss to the AfD in Saxony-Anhalt. The Euroskeptics' success in the state election risks pushing Merz — who already leads the budget-cutting camp — toward an even tougher negotiating stance, diplomats in Brussels told Playbook. (The diplomats were granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive talks.)

The counterargument: German Green MEP Rasmus Andresen said the election result underscores the need for a bigger budget. “Merz and the German government need to understand that further cuts to the budget will only fuel the further rise of right-wing extremism,” he told Playbook.

Meeting the ex: Before the Berlin stop, Costa will meet Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk in Warsaw. As a former European Council president, Tusk understands the negotiations well — and leads a government with its own red lines on how the budget should be financed.

Finding the money: One part of Costa’s effort is to secure support for new EU-wide taxes to finance the budget from 2028 to 2034. He is trying to narrow the list of potentially acceptable levies ahead of a leaders’ summit in Brussels on Oct. 15.

Tax lines: Berlin said at an ambassadors’ meeting yesterday that it would consider all the proposed taxes except CORE, a controversial business levy, according to two EU diplomats. Warsaw supports CORE but opposes a separate proposal to direct revenue from the Emissions Trading System to the EU budget.

The gap: France said at the same meeting that the new EU-wide taxes should generate more than €60 billion — the estimated revenue from the Commission’s proposal last year that several governments have already opposed.

FDDay is Europe’s leading gathering for +4,500 startups, investors, corporates and policymakers. On Sept. 16, join us in Paris for a full day of discussions, meetings and networking focused on the key challenges shaping innovation and European competitiveness. Get 10% off with FDDAY26xPolitico .

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Commission is expected today to unveil plans to update EU public procurement rules. What does it want to achieve? The idea is to require public authorities across the EU to consider factors such as sustainability, supply chain resilience and European production, rather than choosing suppliers primarily on price. The latest draft of the Public Procurement Act will come out alongside a new Innovation Act, which aims to allow public authorities to bring innovations to market faster.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked: if French wine is off the menu, what’s in your glass? WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

FRENCH FAR RIGHT VS. EU PARLIAMENT

BARDELLA’S DAY IN COURT: Jordan Bardella, president of France’s far-right National Rally, has a court date in Luxembourg today as he fights to keep his right-hand man on the European Parliament payroll, Mari Eccles reports.

François Paradol, Bardella’s chief of staff, also used to work as his part-time local MEP assistant. But in 2024, the Parliament said that couldn’t continue, citing tighter rules for parliamentary assistants following a case involving Bardella’s mentor, Marine Le Pen.

Master and apprentice: A French court found Le Pen guilty of embezzling funds meant for MEPs from 2004 to 2016, and using the money to pay for national party staff. The National Rally is on course to

win next year's French election. If Le Pen becomes president, Bardella could well be her prime minister.

Bardella proposed that Paradol work every Monday to Thursday morning as a parliamentary assistant, with the rest of his time set aside for national party work. The Parliament said no, claiming it would be near impossible for Paradol to separate his duties. So Bardella has taken the case to the EU General Court. The hearing is today, but a judgment could take a couple of months.

There's always a local angle: The case could affect how MEPs can choose their own staffers. Paradol told Victor Goury-Laffont last year that by blocking his appointment, the Parliament was attempting to "turn every political aide into a European civil servant."

The Parliament's press service told Playbook that the institution "does not comment on ongoing judicial cases."

7 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

IRAN WAR WATCH: Iran launched a barrage of missiles at American targets in Jordan overnight, after U.S. forces struck five Iranian oil tankers, CNN reports .

BUY EUROPE, ANNOY EVERYONE? Brussels' new public procurement framework lands today and our Pro colleagues are on the case: Morning Fair Play has what to expect ... Morning Health looks at the impact on medtech and pharma ... Morning Agri digs into the food chapter ... and Morning Trade explains why it risks alienating EU allies. (For subscribers.)

HOUSTON, WE MAY NOT NEED YOU: Europe's space chief wants a decision this year on whether the continent should develop the ability to launch its own astronauts — no NASA required.

MERZ'S MORNING AFTER: The AfD's triumph in Saxony-Anhalt has thrown Friedrich Merz's coalition into turmoil, with his SPD partners now turning against the reforms they agreed to push through with the chancellor.

How Washington sees it: Donald Trump celebrated the AfD's breakthrough in a post on Truth Social last night, attributing the state election result to voters getting fed up with Germany's "absolutely horrible" migration laws.

POLAND FRETS AS GERMANY REARMS: Warsaw wants a stronger German military — but Radosław Sikorski has warned that the AfD's rise makes all that new firepower rather less comforting .

BUDAPEST CLEANS HOUSE: Hungary has expelled 10 Russian diplomats over alleged "unacceptable activities," amid concerns about espionage.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals with some rain about. High of 19C.

MOVERS AND SHAKERS: Mario Draghi's former spokesperson and speechwriter Ferdinando Giugliano has been appointed director of the Institute for International Political Studies, one of Italy's leading think tanks ... Jooyeon Ellen Kang, South Korea's deputy head of mission to Belgium, the EU and NATO, has been appointed ambassador to Ireland.

SPOTTED ... at Socialists and Democrats' chief Iratxe García's rentrée speech at the New Economy Forum in the Cercle Royal Gaulois: Committee of the Regions President Kata Tüttő; Spanish Secretary of State for the European Union Fernando Sampedro; Parliament Vice President Javi López and Quaestor Marc Angel; MEPs Javier Moreno and Fernando López Aguilar; Parliament media director Jesús Carmona; Marc Berruezo, director at beBartlet Intelligence; and Spanish business federation CEOE's European Affairs Director Isabel Yglesias Julià.

LET'S GET CULTURAL, CULTURAL: Dust off your finest raincoat and swing a scarf around your neck — the autumn is here and Brussels' arts, culture and heritage season is in full swing. Playbook's Gabriel Gavin brings you everything you need to know to get through the coming weeks of colder weather, and emerge a little more refined ...

Open book: Ibon Landa Amutxategi, a 32-year-old Bilbao artist, is exhibiting a series of artworks exploring reading, the written word and the printed image, opening today at AFFILIATE in the city center, the international offshoot of the WIELS Contemporary Art Centre. It's free to attend; more info [here](#) .

On his high horse: South African artist William Kentridge has an exhibition from Sept. 18 to March 7 in one of the main galleries at Bozar, entitled "I am not me, the horse is not mine." It will feature large-scale installations from throughout his half-century career. More information and tickets [here](#) .

Brussels Heritage Days: Some of the city's most iconic and unusual locations will again open their doors on Sept. 19 and 20, from lesser-known castles dotted around the Belgian capital to the tower of the Cathedral of St. Michael and St. Gudula in the Quartier Royal, the municipal government has confirmed .

Designing childhood: There's still time to catch the Design Museum Brussels' exhibition on the evolution of children's furniture from the 1920s to the modern day before it ends on Sept. 27. It features everything from toy alcoves to kids' bedrooms. More details [here](#) .

Installation nation: Belgian-Polish artist Tapta (born Maria Wierusz-Kowalski) and American minimalist Donald Judd are the focus of a new exhibition opening Oct. 6 at the Royal Museums of Fine Arts of Belgium .

SPICE, SPICE BABY: There's a new party game in Brussels courtesy of Nepali comms officer-turned-entrepreneur Pooja Khati, whose chili oil is becoming a staple at events in the bubble. Khati told Playbook at a joint Comms Collective and Social Capital event on Tuesday night that she married her bubble knowledge with her passion for spice to sell the locally made oil , with tastings and contests to find the spiciest take about working in the EU capital.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Ulrich Siegmund has a realistic shot at taking power in Saxony-Anhalt — but it's less clear whether the state AfD leader is willing to compromise to make it happen.

Paris: Edouard Philippe's appeal to France's centrists to band together was met with shrugs by his presidential rivals.

London: Andy Burnham's government is facing a fierce backlash over its move to impose sanctions targeting Israeli settlements.

Washington: A string of surprise polls has thrust a slate of long-shot candidates into the national spotlight as midterm campaigning ramps up.

Canberra: PM Anthony Albanese says his new social media laws will take power away from Big Tech and hand it to “ordinary Australians.”

AGENDA

— The College of Commissioners meets in Brussels. Followed by a press conference on the Affordable Housing Act with Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera and Housing Commissioner Dan Jørgensen. Watch .

— European Council President António Costa meets Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk in Warsaw, then travels to Berlin for talks with German Chancellor Friedrich Merz. Press conference with Merz at 6:15 p.m. Watch live .

— Coreper II meets in Brussels at 10 a.m.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen participates in an exchange of views with the European Parliament’s Conference of Presidents.

— Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné and Innovation Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva will give a press conference on the Public Procurement Act. Watch live .

— Jørgensen will make a statement to the Parliament on the Affordable Housing Act at 4:30 p.m. Watch live .

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola receives participants in a women’s empowerment program for senior leaders of Ukraine’s Verkhovna Rada at 9 a.m.

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets Japanese Finance Minister Satsuki Katayama in Tokyo.

— International Space Summit in Paris. Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius will give a speech at 2:35 p.m. Watch live .

— Spanish Foreign Minister José Manuel Albares will meet EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas and Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica.

— Séjourné receives South Korean Trade, Industry and Resources Minister Jung-Kwan Kim.

— Health Commissioner Olivér Várhelyi meets Spanish Secretary of State for Health Javier Padilla.

BIRTHDAYS

John Alistair Clarke, the Commission’s former director of international affairs; AP’s Matt Lee; the Commission’s Emiliano Tornese.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

******A message from Connect Europe: Two years after the Draghi report, only 15.7% of its recommendations have been fully implemented. In digital and technology, the figure is just 6.4%. Meanwhile, AI, cloud, defence technology and satellite connectivity are advancing fast. Our DG Alessandro Gropelli argues that Europe needs stronger telecom networks, more investment as well as better and faster decisions to remain competitive. Technology is accelerating. Can Europe keep up? Read the article. ******

* Sponsor: Connect Europe

* The advertisement relates to EU technology and connectivity policy and promotes the FT-Connect Europe Forum, highlighting debates on the Digital Networks Act, market consolidation, investment and the balance between security and innovation in Europe's digital sector.

More information about political advertising here .

SUBSCRIBE to the POLITICO newsletter family: Brussels Playbook | London Playbook | London Playbook PM | Playbook Paris | Berlin Playbook | Sunday Crunch | EU Influence | London Influence | D.C. Playbook | D.C. Influence | Canada Playbook | POLITICO Forecast | Canberra Playbook | All our POLITICO Pro policy morning newsletters

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update your preferences](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium